
FROM SIBLING RIVALRY TO FRIENDS AND CONFIDANTS

Lesson Two

The Favouritism Trap

Watching ourselves: the tone we use, the expectations we set, and the assumptions we make about what each child can carry.

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Before we start

Lesson One was about reading your children. This one is about reading yourself.

This is the harder lesson, if we're honest. It's easier to talk about what our kids are doing than to sit with the quieter question: what am I doing, without even noticing, that's shaping how they see themselves against each other?

No parent sets out to have a favourite. But most parents, if they slow down enough to look, will find a slightly softer tone for one child, a slightly higher bar for another, a slightly different story they've quietly written about who each child is. This lesson isn't about guilt. It's about noticing, because noticing is the only thing that lets us choose differently.

Why this matters more than it seems to

This isn't a small parenting nuance: it's one of the most consistently studied drivers of how children turn out. Researchers call it parental differential treatment, and the evidence on it is remarkably consistent: children who feel they're treated less favourably than their sibling carry that difference into their mental health, their behaviour, and their sense of self.

A large-scale analysis pooling data from more than 37,000 children found that the more unevenly parents treated their children, the more likely those children were to struggle with depression, anxiety, aggression, and rule-breaking. Another major review of over 26,000 children found the same pattern for both internalising struggles, like sadness and worry turned inward, and externalising ones, like acting out. And it

isn't just about who gets less. Research consistently shows that when there's no favouritism at all, siblings simply get on better with each other.

Here's the detail worth sitting with: it's rarely about big, obvious unfairness. It's the accumulation of small moments (a tone, a raised bar, an assumption) that a child adds up over years into a quiet conclusion about where they stand.

Three places favouritism hides

Favouritism rarely announces itself. It hides in three ordinary places, and all three are worth a second look.

1. Tone

The same words can land completely differently depending on how they're said. A request made warmly to one child and clipped to another teaches both of them something about where they stand, long before either child could put it into words.

2. Expectations

This is where age becomes an unfair shortcut. "They're older, they should understand" often means we're asking a child to manage something their brain genuinely isn't ready for yet, not because they won't, but because they can't, not fully, not yet. Research on this exact pattern shows that when parental expectations of the older child run ahead of what they're developmentally ready for, jealousy and resentment tend to increase, not shrink.

3. Capacity

This is the quiet one. It's the difference between believing a child truly can handle something, and simply needing them to, because it's easier, because we're tired, because the household runs smoother if the "big one" just copes. Children read that gap. They know the difference between being trusted and being relied on out of convenience.

The weekly self-audit

A simple way to catch these patterns before they harden into habits. Not a test to pass, just three honest questions, revisited often.

Lens	Ask yourself	Try this
Tone	Do I speak more gently, more patiently, or more warmly to one of them, without meaning to?	Catch yourself mid-sentence once this week. Notice which child gets the softer voice by default.
Expectations	Am I asking one child to "understand," "cope," or "just get over it" at a level their age hasn't reached yet?	Before asking a child to manage a big feeling alone, ask: would I expect this of a

Lens	Ask yourself	Try this
		child three years younger, in a different family?
Capacity	Am I treating "older" as a synonym for "more able," rather than checking what this particular child can actually carry today?	Notice the moments you say "you're the big one now," and ask whether it's about their readiness, or your relief.

The language that makes the difference

As in Lesson One, small shifts in wording carry a surprising amount of weight, because children aren't just hearing the sentence, they're hearing what it implies about how we see them.

Instead of...	Try...
<i>"Why can't you be more like your sister?"</i>	"You and your sister are different, and that's alright. Let's talk about what's hard for you."
<i>"You're older, you should know better."</i>	"You're still learning this too. Being older doesn't mean you've already got it figured out."
<i>"Just let your brother have it, you've had your turn."</i>	"I know this feels unfair right now. Let's find a way that works for both of you."
<i>"She's just easier than he is."</i>	(Retire this one too. Said in front of them or not, it settles into how both children see themselves.)

Bringing it back to Name It, Ground It, Talk It

This lesson doesn't add a new step to the tool, it protects it. Name It, Ground It, Talk It only works if the naming is genuinely fair: if both children get the same warmth in the moment they're struggling, not just the child who reminds us most of ourselves, or the one who's easiest to soothe.

The goal was never to treat both children identically; they're different people, with different needs. The goal is to make sure any difference in how we respond comes from what each child actually needs in that moment, not from a story we've quietly been telling ourselves about who they are.